

The Programmable Web

Have you ever wondered what else you could do on the Web? Whether a simple mail of yours could execute a chain of programs on the Web? The answer to your doubts lies in the programmable Web, also known as WebHooks.

I have been programming in various script languages for four years now and there have been instances when I created many cascaded requests. Cascaded requests are different in a way that a single request is responsible for performing more than one task. Some gurus also call them chained requests.

The programmable Web is a decentralised concept that is not owned or governed by a company. This means that even you can contribute to it. People across the globe are trying to understand it more deeply and some Internet majors have already implemented it. In simple words, it is a Web where you, as the user, can 'pipe' data between applications, much like the UNIX command line.

Google, being one of the leaders in adapting the programmable Web, introduced WebHooks in many of its applications like Google Alerts, Google Reader and Feedburner.

What are WebHooks?

WebHooks let you extend Web applications, customise them and integrate them using something that cannot be accessed by programming. For a Web developer, it is another design pattern that has the ability to make Web requests and store some extra data about the users. From a user's point of view, they are applications that can generate/trigger events to get data in real-time from that very Web application.

Why do we require WebHooks?

Chaining: They allow your applications to work as a chain or hook linking each to the other, more like executing a program that has a loop, some conditions, etc.

Notifications: When you receive an e-mail, the notification reads, "1 new e-mail received." What if you want the notification to do something more than that?

Data synching: How many times have you had to import your contacts into Gmail, then to Thunderbird or to some other Web